

## KIQ 3.1 — Final Takeaway

*Who are the main competitors offering digital ordering solutions to HoReCa customers in Europe?*

### Methodological note

KIQ 3.1 is a mapping question: it identifies the relevant competitive set for METRO's digital ordering platforms in the European HoReCa market. The indicator (from the scope derivation document) is competitor websites and product pages, industry reports naming key players, app-store presence of competitor ordering tools, and analyst comparisons. Data was gathered through structured web research on each named competitor (corporate sites, product pages, press coverage, app-store listings, LinkedIn presence) and encoded into a CSV inventory with source attribution per row. The CSV is then read by a reproducible script (Python / R) that generates the positioning matrix.

### Selection criteria

Competitors were selected by three criteria: (a) **strategic relevance** — they operate in the same European HoReCa B2B ordering space METRO targets; (b) **digital sophistication** — they offer a public digital ordering channel (web platform, native app, or both); (c) **scale or trajectory** — either they are large enough to set market expectations (Sysco, Amazon Business) or growing fast enough to redefine the rules (Choco, REKKI). The selection covers the two most strategically relevant players in each category established in KIQ 2.2.

### Scope note — how Sysco and Amazon are treated

Two competitors require a scope clarification. **Sysco** is included as the global industry benchmark and as the parent of European foodservice operations — it owns **Brakes (UK)** and **Davigel (FR)**, acquired in 2016. Its analysed digital platforms (Sysco Shop, MySysco Order, and Sysco Marketplace on Mirakl) are primarily North-American; in Europe its presence runs through Brakes' web ordering portal (mybrakes), which is web-based rather than a public mobile app. Sysco therefore appears in the platform-capability and feature analyses (this KIQ and KIQ 3.2) as the global benchmark, but is necessarily absent from the public app-review perception analysis (KIQ 3.3), because its European arm has no reviewable consumer app. This is not an inconsistency but consistent scope discipline: each competitor is included exactly where the indicator and the European geography permit. **Amazon Business** is likewise treated as an adjacent benchmark rather than a direct HoReCa competitor: it is the B2C-to-B2B expectation-setter, not a foodservice distributor.

### Competitor inventory

| Competitor                    | Type                      | Digital platform(s)                                                                                                              | Geography                           | Scale / notes                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>METRO (reference)</b>      | Incumbent B2B foodservice | M Shop (companion app for stores); METRO MARKETS (hybrid marketplace); M Companion; DISH (POS / restaurant tools)                | ~30 countries (Europe + adj.)       | €31B sales; 15–17M customers; sCore 2030 targets 40% digital                                                                         |
| <b>Sysco</b>                  | Incumbent B2B foodservice | MySysco Order (web + mobile, 24/7); Sysco Shop (e-commerce); Sysco Marketplace (Mirakl-powered hybrid, 15k+ 3rd-party SKUs)      | US-led; UK + EU via Brakes, Davigel | ~\$40B sales; 80% indep. biz digital; \$450M incremental from personalization (2021–24); \$29.1B Restaurant Depot acquisition (2026) |
| <b>Bidcorp / Bidfood</b>      | Incumbent B2B foodservice | eBidfood / Bidfood platform (single-supplier, UX-focused); country apps under Bidcorp umbrella                                   | UK + EU + global (35+ countries)    | ZAR 256B (~€13B) revenue; strong UK presence; platform praised for user-friendliness and service                                     |
| <b>Transgourmet / Selgros</b> | Incumbent B2B foodservice | Transgourmet B2B native app (React Native, 2021, single-supplier); B2C app relaunched 2024; unified Drupal/Commercetools backend | DE, FR, CH, AT, PL, RO, RU          | Europe's 2nd-largest food wholesaler; part of Coop Group; €3B+ revenue in Germany alone                                              |

|                        |                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                 |                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Choco</b>           | Digital-native B2B HoReCa | Choco mobile app (free for restaurants, pure aggregator); AI-powered ordering, voice/email/text capture, ERP integration, AI quoting                                                             | DE, FR, ES, AT, BE, UK, US                      | Founded 2018 (Berlin); \$111M Series B (2024); 350% YoY user growth; targets 100% digital food wholesale by 2026              |
| <b>REKKI</b>           | Digital-native B2B HoReCa | REKKI mobile app (free for restaurants, pure aggregator); in-app supplier chat; supplier discovery; unified payments                                                                             | UK, NL, PT, US (ops London/NY/Amsterdam/Lisbon) | Founded 2016; 10,000+ restaurants worldwide; ~80 staff; free for restaurants; payments on terms or per-invoice                |
| <b>Amazon Business</b> | Adjacent B2C-to-B2B giant | Web + app (hybrid marketplace); 300+ procurement integrations (Coupa, Ariba, SAP Concur, Oracle NetSuite, Restaurant 365, etc.); multi-location workflows; same-day perishable grocery (2025–26) | US, Europe, global                              | Hospitality vertical (hotels, restaurants, cruise, casinos); leverages consumer-side Amazon scale and UX into B2B procurement |

## Marketplace typology — three distinct models

"Marketplace" is not a single business model. Across the competitive set, three distinct configurations co-exist, and the distinction between them is strategically consequential for METRO:

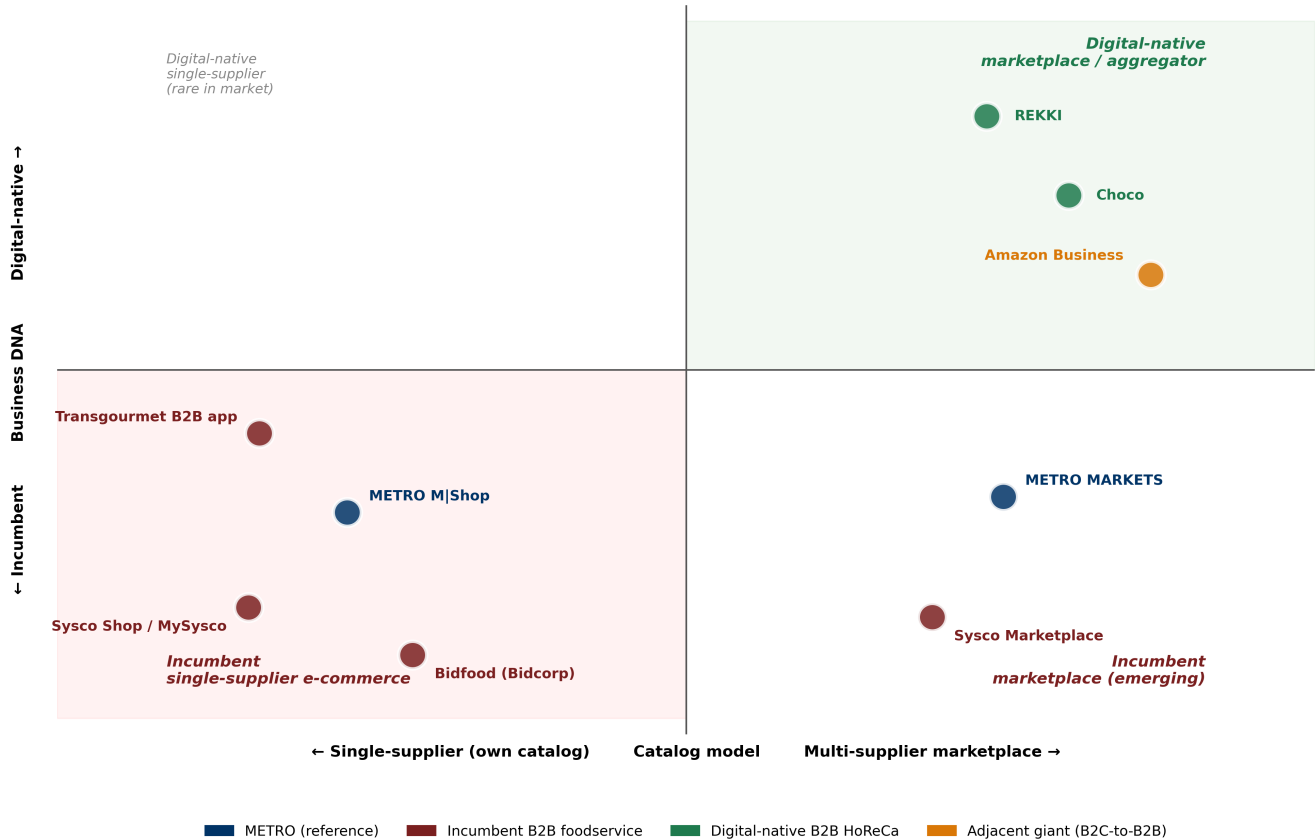
| Model                              | Owns inventory?       | 3rd-party vendors? | Who fulfills?                                 | Examples in the set                                       |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Single-supplier own catalog</b> | Yes                   | No                 | The wholesaler itself                         | METRO M Shop, Sysco Shop / MySysco, Bidfood, Transgourmet |
| <b>Hybrid marketplace</b>          | Yes (own + 3rd party) | Yes                | Wholesaler OR authorized 3rd parties          | METRO MARKETS, Sysco Marketplace, Amazon Business         |
| <b>Pure aggregator marketplace</b> | No                    | Yes                | Individual suppliers (platform routes orders) | Choco, REKKI                                              |

On the positioning matrix, the X-axis — *catalog model* — should be read as a **gradient, not a binary**: single-supplier → hybrid marketplace → pure aggregator. REKKI and Choco occupy the far right (pure aggregators, no inventory); METRO MARKETS, Sysco Marketplace, and Amazon Business sit in the middle (hybrid: own inventory + 3rd-party vendors); the single-supplier incumbents sit on the left (own catalog only).

## Positioning matrix

Plotting the inventory on two strategic axes — **catalog model** (single-supplier own-catalog → hybrid marketplace → pure aggregator) and **business DNA** (legacy incumbent → digital-native) — reveals the structural shape of the competitive landscape:

KIQ 3.1 — Competitive positioning of digital ordering platforms for European HoReCa



### Finding 1 — The market splits cleanly along the two axes

Incumbents (METRO, Sysco, Bidcorp, Transgourmet) historically cluster in the bottom-left quadrant: single-supplier digital platforms layered on top of their physical distribution networks. Digital-natives (Choco, REKKI) cluster in the top-right: pure-aggregator marketplace platforms that own zero inventory and route orders from chefs to independent suppliers. Amazon Business sits in the same digital-native quadrant by DNA, but at radically larger scale and with a hybrid (not pure-aggregator) model.

### Finding 2 — Incumbents are crossing into the marketplace quadrant — as hybrids, not pure aggregators

Both METRO (METRO MARKETS) and Sysco (Sysco Marketplace, launched 2024 on Mirakl) have moved into the bottom-right quadrant — but as **hybrid marketplaces**, not pure aggregators. Their marketplaces are layered on top of their own catalogs and logistics, with 3rd-party vendors added alongside their primary inventory. This is structurally distinct from REKKI and Choco, which own no inventory at all and act purely as discovery + payments + routing layers between buyers and independent suppliers. The two marketplace flavors compete for the same end customers but solve different problems: hybrid marketplaces are a **catalog-expansion** play (adding assortment without holding stock); pure aggregators are a **distribution-disruption** play (removing the wholesaler-as-distributor from the value chain).

### Finding 3 — METRO is the only incumbent in both quadrants simultaneously

METRO M|Shop is positioned in the incumbent single-supplier quadrant; METRO MARKETS in the incumbent hybrid-marketplace quadrant. Sysco has the same dual structure (Sysco Shop + Sysco Marketplace) but its marketplace is younger (2024) and US-focused. Bidcorp and Transgourmet are still single-supplier. METRO's dual-quadrant position is a strategic asset: it can serve professional buyers who want curated METRO catalogs *and* buyers who want one-stop multi-supplier access — without losing either to a digital-native pure-aggregator or to Amazon Business.

## Finding 4 — The digital-native threat is concentrated and well-funded

Choco (\$111M Series B, 7-country EU presence) and REKKI (10,000+ restaurants, multi-country) are the two competitors most likely to redefine restaurateur expectations of what a B2B ordering app should feel like — in the same way that Uber Eats redefined consumer food-delivery UX. Both offer their apps free to restaurants, capture revenue from suppliers, and are AI-investing aggressively (Choco's AI quoting, voice/email/SMS capture). They are not direct catalog competitors to METRO — but they are direct *experience* competitors: they shape what HoReCa buyers expect a digital ordering tool to do.

## Finding 5 — Incumbents do not build their platforms — they buy from infrastructure providers

An additional pattern surfaces from the competitor research: every incumbent in the set operates a platform built on third-party infrastructure rather than in-house technology. Sysco Marketplace runs on **Miraki** (French marketplace SaaS, also used by Carrefour, Best Buy Canada, Leroy Merlin); Bidfood Direct is built on **Adobe Commerce / Magento** via the iWeb agency; Transgourmet / Selgros operates a unified **Drupal + Commercetools + React Native** stack via the 1xINTERNET agency; METRO MARKETS was built by Hamburg software firm **freiheit.com** with ERP delivered by **DataArt**. Only the digital-natives (Choco, REKKI) and the adjacent giant (Amazon Business) operate proprietary stacks built in-house. This pattern corroborates the KIQ 2.2 finding (foodservice incumbents file zero patents in digital ordering) by revealing its mechanism: incumbents are technology *buyers*, not technology *inventors*. The strategic decision is therefore not whether to build a platform, but which infrastructure partner to choose, which capabilities to keep in-house, and which digital-native to acquire.

## Direct answer to KIQ 3.1

The main competitors offering digital ordering solutions to European HoReCa customers are organized into three strategic groups across three marketplace flavors. **Incumbent B2B foodservice distributors** (Sysco, Bidcorp/Bidfood, Transgourmet/Selgros) operate single-supplier own-catalog e-commerce platforms rooted in their physical distribution networks; Sysco and METRO have additionally extended into hybrid-marketplace mode. **Digital-native HoReCa platforms** (Choco, REKKI) operate pure-aggregator mobile-first apps that own no inventory, are free for restaurants, and aggressively invest in AI-driven UX. **Amazon Business** is the adjacent giant: a digital-native hybrid marketplace at consumer-platform scale, with hospitality verticalization underway, capable of disrupting the competitive set at any time. METRO's digital portfolio (M|Shop + METRO MARKETS + M|Companion + DISH) is the only set in the competitive field that spans both the incumbent single-supplier and the incumbent hybrid-marketplace quadrants simultaneously — a dual structure shared only by Sysco at scale.

## Bottom line

The European HoReCa digital-ordering competitive set is structured along two axes — catalog model (with a single-supplier → hybrid → pure-aggregator gradient) and business DNA — and shaped by three groups. METRO and Sysco are the only incumbents straddling single-supplier

and hybrid-marketplace modes. Choco and REKKI are the pure-aggregator experience-setters. Amazon Business is the latent threat. The strategic challenge for METRO is not the catalog war (it already operates in both incumbent quadrants) — it is the experience war: matching the UX, speed, and AI-personalization that digital-native pure aggregators are training HoReCa buyers to expect.

## Bridge to KIQ 3.2 and KIQ 3.3

KIQ 3.1 identifies **who** METRO competes against and clarifies **what kind of marketplace** each competitor operates. KIQ 3.2 will compare these platforms on **features and usability** (functional positioning, where the inventory / fulfillment / payment differences surface as concrete user-facing features); KIQ 3.3 will surface **customer perception** through app-store review sentiment analysis (perceptual positioning). Together the three KIQs deliver an actor / feature / perception view on the same competitive set, completing the KIT 3 key-players-and-positioning analysis.

## Defending the analytical choices

### Why these seven competitors and not more?

Adding more regional incumbents (Pomona, Marr, Edeka C+C, Booker, JJ Foodservice, Foodomarket, etc.) would inflate the inventory without adding strategic insight: they are smaller in scale, geographically constrained, and digitally less differentiated. The seven competitors selected cover the two most strategically relevant players in each of three categories established in KIQ 2.2 — that is enough to map the competitive structure without diluting focus. Long-tail regional players are acknowledged but not analyzed individually.

### Why the two-axis positioning matrix?

Catalog model (single-supplier → hybrid → pure aggregator) and business DNA (incumbent vs. digital-native) are the two structural dimensions that emerged from the data — not from a pre-defined framework. They were chosen because they cleanly separate the competitors into distinguishable strategic groups and because they expose the strategic move that matters most for METRO: incumbents are crossing the catalog axis into hybrid-marketplace mode while digital-natives operate on a fundamentally different (inventory-free) model. A feature-by-feature comparison (the natural alternative axes) is the work of KIQ 3.2, not KIQ 3.1.

### Why is "marketplace" treated as a gradient rather than a binary?

Public-source descriptions of REKKI, Choco, METRO MARKETS, Sysco Marketplace, and Amazon Business all use the word "marketplace," but the underlying business models differ in three fundamental ways: who owns inventory, whether 3rd-party vendors are present, and who handles fulfillment. The matrix therefore treats marketplace position as a gradient (single-supplier → hybrid → pure aggregator) rather than a binary classification, which preserves the analytical resolution needed to distinguish strategically different platforms that share the same surface vocabulary.